Lesson Plan: Asking for a Raise by Email

B2 (intermediate) | 18 adult ESL learners | Adult intensive ESL program | 50 minutes | Task-based instruction

Objectives

Goal of the lesson: To help students communicate in a real-life workplace situation by writing a clear, polite email to their supervisors, discussing a raise using adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition accurately.

Content objectives

Students will:

- write a clear, polite email to your boss requesting a discussion about a raise.
- reply to a coworker's request with a decision and a reason.
- revise their email so that it is clear, polite, and professional.

Language objectives

Students will:

- use at least four adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition (e.g., *because, although, even though, unless, even if*) accurately and appropriately in their email.
- identify the type of adverb clause (cause, contrast, or condition) in sentences they hear and read.
- avoid sentence fragments beginning with *because* and avoid double connectors.

Key concepts and vocabulary

- **Adverb clause words:** cause: *because*; contrast: *although, even though, while*; condition: *unless, even if, whether or not*.
- **Nouns:** raise, salary, responsibilities, request, budget.
- **Verbs and phrases:** ask for, discuss, appreciate, consider, would like to.

Materials

- Projector or slides, whiteboard and markers
- Review chart and sentence strips (Appendix A, below)
- Model email (Appendix B, below)
- Peer review and reply sheet (Appendix C, below)
- Common-error examples (Appendix D, below)
- Job Cards and Planning Sheet with word bank (separate PDF)
- Assessment rubric and bilingual dictionaries

Before class, the teacher should:

- Prepare and display the content and language objectives.
- Prepare the slides, sentence strips, and job cards.
- Print the planning sheet, model email, and peer review and reply sheet (one per student).
- Prepare the rubric based on use of adverb clauses, clear and polite message, organization, and grammar and punctuation.

Procedure

Stage	Time	What happens
Motivation (pre-task)	5 min	Students read the lesson objectives silently, then read them aloud together. The teacher displays this situation: “You have worked at your job for one year. You now do more tasks than when you started, but your salary is still the same.” The teacher asks: “What would you do? Whom would you contact? What would you say?” Students turn to their partner to discuss these questions and how they would ask for a raise at their workplace. The teacher explains that students will write a request email and reply to a partner’s email.
Review and model (pre-task)	12 min	Quick review: show a chart of the three adverb clause types and review one example of each (Appendix A). Review the comma rule: use a comma after an adverb clause at the beginning of a sentence; a comma is usually not needed when the clause comes at the end. In pairs, students sort six sentence strips into cause, contrast, and condition (Appendix A). Check the answers with the whole class and correct quickly. Point to the word bank on the planning sheet. **Model the task:** students will write an email to their supervisor requesting a raise, including reasons, a contrast, and a condition (at least 4 adverbial clauses). Then a partner will reply as the boss. The teacher reads the model email (Appendix B) aloud; students underline the adverb clauses and name their types. The teacher points out polite language (*I would like to…, I would appreciate…*), explains how to use the planning sheet and word bank, and reminds students to avoid fragments beginning with *because* and to punctuate opening clauses correctly. Each student draws a job card and predicts which clause type will be used for each piece of information (reason, company situation, offer).
Main task (task)	23 min	Students use their job cards and planning sheets to plan their ideas. Students write their emails independently, using the word bank and sentence frames as needed. The teacher moves around, monitors the students’ progress, and provides support when necessary. After some minutes, students exchange their emails with their partners. Each partner reads the email as if they were the supervisor and completes the peer-review checklist (Appendix C). The partner then writes a reply of two or three sentences with a decision and a reason, using at least one adverb clause, and returns it. Several students read their request and the reply aloud. The class says whether the request was accepted and which adverb clauses made the message clear and polite.
Feedback and review (post-task)	10 min	Review common errors: the teacher shows common errors from student writing (anonymously) on slides (Appendix D): fragments beginning with *because*, comma misuse, double connectors, wrong tense in the clause, and impolite tone. Students identify each error and suggest a correction, and the teacher explains using correct models. Students revise their emails using the feedback and the peer review sheet. One to three volunteers read a revised sentence that shows accurate use of an adverb clause. Students return to the objectives and assess whether they met them.
Homework		Students finish revising their email. Then they write a second email about a different real situation (for example, asking a supervisor to change a work schedule or asking an advisor for an appointment) that uses at least four adverb clauses. Students bring both emails to the next class.

Assessment

Assessment is formative, and it takes place throughout the lesson.

- Pre-task: the teacher checks prior knowledge through the sorting activity and listens to pair discussion to note areas needing clarification.
- Task: the teacher circulates and gives brief support. Partners use the peer review and reply sheet (Appendix C) to check use of clauses, clarity, and politeness.
- Post-task: the teacher checks revisions and listens to volunteer examples for improved accuracy.

Appendix A: Review chart and sentence strips

Type		Words	Example
Cause	give a reason	*because*	I am asking for a raise *because I train new employees now*.
Contrast	show an unexpected or opposite idea	*although, even though, while*	*Although the budget is tight*, I believe my work has grown.
Condition	say what depends on something	*unless, even if, whether or not*	I can work extra shifts *unless I have class*.

Comma rule: When the adverb clause comes at the beginning of the sentence, put a comma after it. When it comes at the end, usually do not use a comma.

Sentence strip	Answer
I am asking for a raise because I train new employees now.	Cause
Although the budget is tight, I believe my work has grown.	Contrast
I can take extra shifts unless I have a class.	Condition
While I understand the company had a slow year, I would like to discuss my salary.	Contrast
Even if a raise is not possible now, I would like your feedback.	Condition

Appendix B: Model email

Subject: Request to discuss my salary

Dear Mr. Carter,

I am writing to ask if we can discuss a raise **because I have taken on more responsibilities since January**. **Although I know the company budget is limited this year**, I believe my work now supports the team in new ways. I am happy to meet at any time that works for you, **unless you are traveling next week**. **Even if a raise is not possible right now**, I would appreciate your feedback on how I can grow in this role.

Thank you for considering my request.

Sincerely,
Maria

Teacher note: Students underline the adverb clauses (shown in bold) and name each type: cause, contrast, condition.

Appendix C: Pair review sheet

Part 1. Review (the partner reads as the boss)

Question	Yes	Needs work
Is the request clear?	☐	☐
Is there a reason with *because*?	☐	☐
Is there a contrast clause (*although, even though, while*)?	☐	☐
Is there a condition clause (*unless, even if, whether or not*)?	☐	☐
Is there a comma after a clause at the beginning of a sentence?	☐	☐
Is the email polite and professional?	☐	☐

One thing I liked: _____

One thing to improve: _____

Appendix D: Common errors for post-task slides (samples)

The teacher replaces or adds errors from real student writing from the lesson. Each sample shows the error and the correction.

Error type	Error	Correction
Fragment	I deserve a raise. Because I work hard.	I deserve a raise because I work hard.
Missing comma	Although the budget is small I have more work.	Although the budget is small, I have more work.
Double connector	Although the budget is small, but I work hard.	Although the budget is small, I work hard.
Tense in the clause	Unless you will be busy, I would like to meet next week.	Unless you are busy, I would like to meet next week.
Tone	Even if you say no, I will quit.	Even if a raise is not possible now, I would appreciate your feedback.